

Concept tags for work in Week 4: emotionally durable design, repair as understanding, longevity (SEMINAL), service, craftsmanship, constraint as identity

30 year interview with my grandmother:

The first person to come to mind when Dr. Eagle explained the 30-year project was my grandmother. Her home is like a fossilized apartment of my childhood. Almost nothing has changed at all, she still uses tupperware and dishes and pots and pans that I saw her use as I danced around her kitchen when I was 4. If there is anyone that has owned one product for 30 years it would definitely be her.

In our conversation over the phone, she told me that she has kept many things, most of which she kept in her childhood home in the Dominican Republic and could not bring when she immigrated to the United States with my mother and uncle. The one thing she can remember having and still using for that long is her sewing machine. She could no longer read the brand because the logo and all other writing had worn off.

She worked in a dress manufacturing factory, mainly sewing buttons onto dresses. With this, and being the oldest daughter in a family of 18 children and a mother to 3 young kids, she became an expert seamstress. I can still remember hearing the hum of the sewing machine and watching as she patched my mothers clothes and our halloween costumes.

When I asked her how she had managed to keep something working for so long, she told me that she treats all of her most useful and meaningful possessions with care. She sets time aside to sit down and properly analyze her possessions and takes them apart the best she can and cleans them thoroughly so they don't wear as much over time. She still owns box fans from 30 years ago that she used to cool her home in the Dominican Republic when she lived there; she has pots and pans that have been around at least since when I was born 20 years ago and still look brand new today; she own teddy bears and dolls that family gifted my mom and aunt and uncle when they were just kids. This is how she demonstrated **Chapman's theory on Emotionally Durable Design** where he states that "we throw things away not because they break but because we stop caring about them." Because these products were designed for an essential purpose – to cook, to cool, etc. – my grandmother decided to care for them. In time, these objects have become an aspect of her identity and are associated with specific memories, not just for her but for her family as well.